

World War II: The Home Front

Trace how World War II reshaped the American home front across four systems — political, economic, social-cultural, and geographic — and weigh who benefited and who bore the costs.

? Historical challenge

World War II was fought overseas, but it transformed life inside the United States. The war remade American politics, the economy, society and culture, and where people lived — and it did so unevenly. Follow the war's shockwaves outward through four systems, weigh who benefited and who bore the costs, and decide which change left the deepest mark.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Executive Order 9066 (1942) – National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The order that led to the forced removal and incarceration of Japanese Americans.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did EO 9066 authorize?
- Who bore the costs of this policy?

SOURCES 2

The Home Front by the Numbers – The National WWII Museum

SECONDARY SOURCE

War production, rationing, and workforce statistics for the home front.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How did the U.S. economy change during the war?
- What evidence shows the scale of mobilization?

SOURCES 3

Rosie the Riveter: Working Women and World War II – Library of Congress

SECONDARY SOURCE

How women's wartime work changed the workforce and its image.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How did women's roles change during the war?
- What happened to those opportunities after 1945?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

THE EVENT

The U.S. Home Front in World War II

1941–1945

The United States

Political

IMMEDIATE EFFECT

Federal declarations of war and a rapid expansion of federal power — new war agencies, the draft, and censorship coordination.

SECONDARY EFFECT

Executive Order 9066 (1942) authorized the incarceration of Japanese Americans, while Executive Order 8802 (1941) created the Fair Employment Practices Committee — government now directly shaping civil rights and civil liberties.

EVIDENCE

Executive Order 9066; Korematsu v. United States (1944); Executive Order 8802.

Economic

IMMEDIATE EFFECT

Industry converted to war production; deficit spending and war contracts ended the Depression and drove near-full employment; rationing managed scarce goods.

SECONDARY EFFECT

Postwar prosperity and an expanding middle class, fueled by wartime savings, war bonds, and the 1944 GI Bill.

EVIDENCE

~300,000 aircraft and 86,000 tanks produced; OPA ration books; the GI Bill of 1944.

Social / cultural

IMMEDIATE EFFECT

Women entered war industries in large numbers ('Rosie the Riveter'); propaganda and shared sacrifice mobilized

Geographic / environmental

IMMEDIATE EFFECT

Massive internal migration to war-production centers (the West Coast, Detroit, the Gulf Coast), causing housing

civilian culture.
SECONDARY EFFECT

Wartime experience reshaped expectations for women and minorities and seeded postwar civil-rights momentum (the 'Double V' campaign).

EVIDENCE

~3 million women in defense plants; War Manpower Commission and OWI posters; the Tuskegee Airmen and Navajo Code Talkers.

shortages and crowding.
SECONDARY EFFECT

Lasting demographic shifts — growth of the West and Sunbelt, permanent urbanization of Black and Latino populations, and the forced relocation of Japanese Americans to remote inland camps.

EVIDENCE

Continuation of the Great Migration; camps such as Manzanar (California) and Topaz (Utah); wartime 'boomtowns.'

Who benefited?

Industrial workers and the previously unemployed (jobs, higher wages); women and minorities gaining new (if temporary) economic footholds; returning veterans (the GI Bill); defense industries, farmers, and the broader postwar economy.

Who bore the costs?

Japanese Americans — about 120,000 incarcerated under EO 9066, losing homes, businesses, and liberty; combat casualties and Gold Star families; consumers under rationing; and Black and other minority workers who still faced discrimination and segregation despite the FEPC.

Which effect had the greatest significance? Explain with evidence.

Of the home front's effects — a wartime economy that ended the Depression, new opportunities for women and minorities, expanded federal power, or the incarceration of Japanese Americans — which mattered most in shaping the United States? Use specific evidence to defend which had the deepest or most lasting impact, and for whom.

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your four pathways with a partner. Did you find the same immediate and secondary effects?
- Did you rank the same effect as most lasting? Defend your ranking with evidence.

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

WWII transformed the home front across systems: expanded federal power (war agencies, the draft, but also EO 9066 and the FEPC); a war economy that ended the Depression and built the postwar middle class (GI Bill); new but temporary openings for women and minorities; and large internal migrations that reshaped where Americans lived. Costs and benefits fell unevenly — most starkly on the ~120,000 Japanese Americans incarcerated under EO 9066.

Common misconceptions

- The war economy, not the New Deal alone, ended the Great Depression.
- New opportunities for women and minorities were real but often rolled back after 1945.
- The GI Bill's benefits were unevenly accessible — many Black veterans were effectively excluded.

Vocabulary

Arsenal of Democracy, rationing, Executive Order 9066, internment/incarceration, Rosie the Riveter, GI Bill, FEPC, Double V.

Historical context

Pearl Harbor Dec. 7, 1941; EO 8802 (1941); EO 9066 (Feb. 19, 1942); ~120,000 Japanese Americans incarcerated; ~3 million women in defense plants; GI Bill 1944; V-E and V-J Day 1945.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Which home-front effect mattered most in shaping the United States? Support your ranking with specific evidence from at least two pathways and two sources, and address who benefited and who bore the costs.